

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Cesarean Birth (C-Section)

What to expect before, during, and after your surgical delivery

COMMON REASONS FOR C-SECTION

- Failure to progress in labor
- Non-reassuring fetal heart rate
- Breech or transverse baby position
- Placenta previa (placenta over cervix)
- Prior uterine surgery or classical C-section
- Maternal medical conditions (severe preeclampsia)
- Multiple gestation in certain positions

TYPES OF C-SECTION

- **Planned (elective)** — scheduled in advance for known indications
- **Unplanned** — decided during labor for a new indication
- **Emergency** — immediate surgery for fetal or maternal distress
- Most use a low transverse (bikini line) incision
- Classical vertical incision rarely used today

BEFORE SURGERY

- NPO (nothing by mouth) 8 hours before
- IV line placed; antacid medication given
- Spinal or epidural anesthesia — you stay awake
- Foley catheter placed after anesthesia
- Abdomen prepped and sterile drape placed
- Support person may be present in OR
- Surgery typically takes 45–60 minutes total

DURING THE PROCEDURE

- You will feel pressure and pulling — not pain
- Baby is usually delivered within first 5–10 min
- Delayed cord clamping when safe
- Skin-to-skin contact in OR when possible
- Uterus and layers closed; 4–6 skin sutures or staples
- Gentle tummy tuck style closure used

RECOVERY — FIRST 24 HOURS

- Recovery room monitoring 1–2 hours post-op
- Foley catheter removed within 12–24 hours
- Begin walking as soon as anesthesia wears off
- Pain managed with scheduled ibuprofen + Tylenol
- Narcotic pain meds available if needed **RX**
- Hospital stay typically 3 days
- Breastfeeding supported immediately

RECOVERY AT HOME

- No lifting over 10 lbs for 6 weeks
- No driving for 2 weeks or while on narcotics
- Pelvic rest (no sex) for 6 weeks
- Keep incision dry; pat clean; no submerging
- Activity gradually increases over 6 weeks
- Follow-up visit at 2 weeks and 6 weeks post-op
- VBAC may be possible for future pregnancies

⚠️ CALL YOUR DOCTOR OR GO TO ER AFTER DISCHARGE

- ⚠️ Fever over 100.4°F (38°C)
 - ⚠️ Increasing rather than improving pain
 - ⚠️ Foul-smelling vaginal discharge
 - ⚠️ Chest pain or difficulty breathing
- ⚠️ Incision red, swollen, draining, or opening
 - ⚠️ Heavy vaginal bleeding (soaking >1 pad/hour)
 - ⚠️ Calf pain, redness, or leg swelling (clot?)
 - ⚠️ Signs of wound dehiscence (incision opening)

♥️ A Cesarean Birth Is Still a Beautiful Birth

Regardless of how your baby arrives, you are a strong and wonderful mother. A C-section is a major surgery performed to protect you and your baby. Allow yourself to heal — physically and emotionally. Your body has done something remarkable, and your care team is with you every step of the recovery journey.